

We can see the bill. We cannot see the spend.

Cloud is the one large line where spending decisions are made daily, by people who never see the invoice, with no approval step in between.



No owner on the change

When the number moves, naming who caused it takes days — or never happens.



Data arrives after the fact

Billing lands 24-48h late, so every cost alert reports rather than prevents.



Nothing stops a runaway

No quota, no ceiling, no gate. The first hard limit is the invoice.

What this brief asks for

01

A mandatory tagging standard

Enforced at deployment

02

A named owner per application

A person, not a mailing list

03

Guardrails on by default

Quotas and budget thresholds

No new headcount or tooling spend.

WHY NOW

The discipline moved this year — toward us

FinOps Foundation, State of FinOps 2026 (n ≈ 1,500 practitioners worldwide).

78%

of FinOps practices now report
into the CTO/CIO organization

up 18 points since 2023

98%

of practices now manage AI
spend as a core operating cost

SaaS 90% · licensing 64% · data centre
48%

#3

governance ranks above
optimization in 2026 priorities

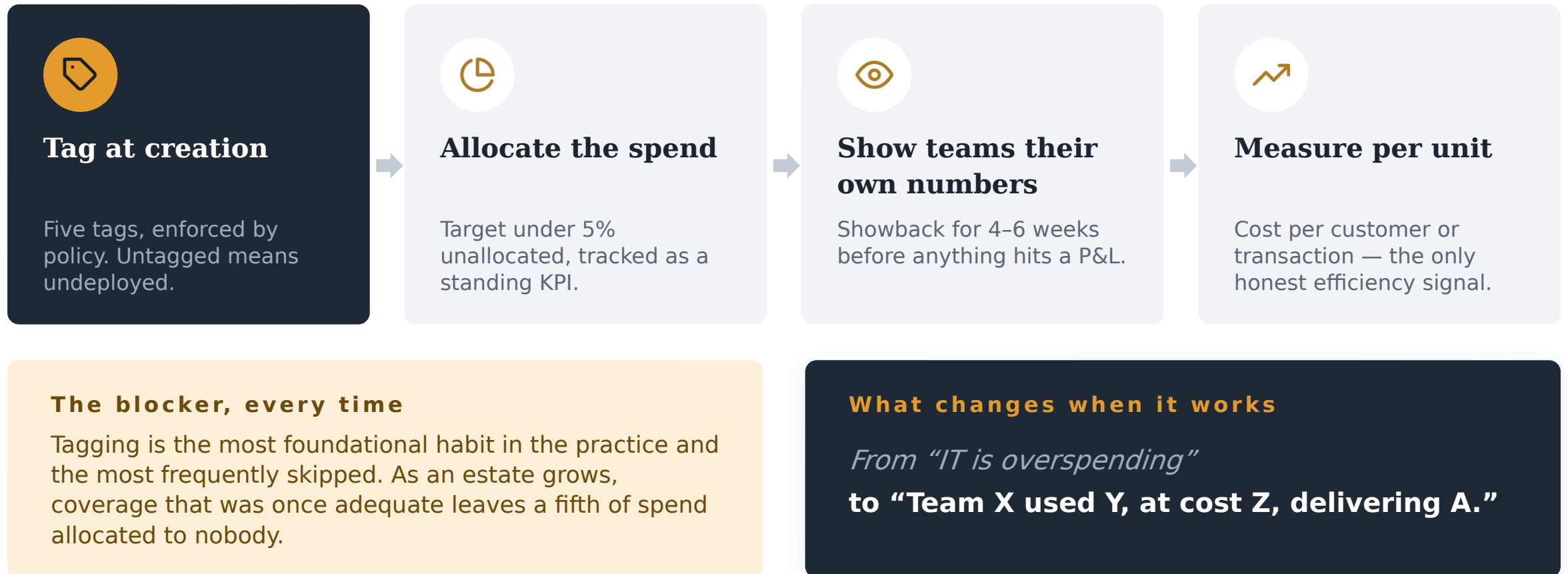
behind only AI cost management and
AI-driven efficiency

What it means for this organization

Cost control has stopped being a finance report and become a technology capability — which puts it on this desk. The industry's own conclusion is that attacking waste after the fact has hit diminishing returns; the returns now come from governance, forecasting and scope.

Allocation is the whole game

Every question worth asking about cloud spend reduces to one prerequisite: can this cost be traced to an owner?



Four controls, and only one of them is fast

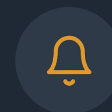
A report is not a control. These are, in the order they take effect.



Rate limits & quotas

seconds

The only control that can stop spend in progress: token and request caps, gateway throttling, autoscale ceilings.



Tiered alerts

minutes to days

Usage-plane alerts page someone. Budget alerts go to a channel. Advisory alerts become tickets — never a page.



Named application owners

always on

One person per workload who owns the budget, answers the alert and retires what is unused.



Budget thresholds

within the month

Notify, review, gate — measured against elapsed month, so drift shows in week one rather than at close.

“A cost alert cannot save you from a runaway job — by the time the billing data moves, the money is spent. Only the usage plane is fast enough.”

THE ASK

Ninety days, three decisions

Weeks 1-4

Standard and baseline

- Publish the tag taxonomy and enforce it on new resources
- Name an owner for every application above a spend floor
- Report allocation coverage as a number, weekly

Weeks 5-8

Guardrails, showback

- Quotas and autoscale ceilings on the top ten workloads
- Alert tiers wired to owners, not to a shared mailbox
- Showback: every team sees its own spend, nothing is charged

Weeks 9-12

Review and decide

- Monthly review with finance in the room
- Unit-cost baseline for the two largest products
- Decide whether and when showback becomes chargeback

Decisions needed today

Do we enforce tagging at deployment?

Who owns the taxonomy — and by when?

Are we willing to have a limit that actually blocks?